

Ctenosaura similis

Black spiny-tailed iguana



Length 28–39 in (70–100 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S. Mexico, Central America



The juvenile black spiny-tailed iguana is bright green, lives in trees, and is hunted by birds of prey. The adult, which has few if any predators, is large and gray, with a spikier tail than the juvenile. Adults bask on rocks or stumps, looking out for invertebrates and insects, and also forage for leaves, fruit, carrion, and scraps. Capable of great speed when running away, this iguana may also bite in defense. Females lay 20–30 eggs in burrows or among tree roots.



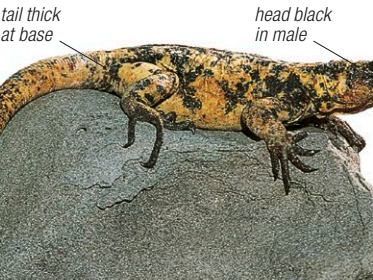
Sauromalus obesus

Chuckwalla



Length 11–16½ in (28–42 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S.W. USA, N.W. Mexico



This lizard employs an unusual form of defense: it retreats into rocky crevices and jams itself in by inflating the folds of loose skin on its neck, throat, and flanks, making it hard for predatory birds and mammals to pull it out. It requires very hot conditions before it becomes active, and remains in the crevices in cold weather. In hot weather, it emerges to bask and forage for fruit, leaves, and flowers of succulent plants. Females lay 5–16 eggs, often only in alternate years.

Phrynosoma platyrhinos

Desert horned lizard



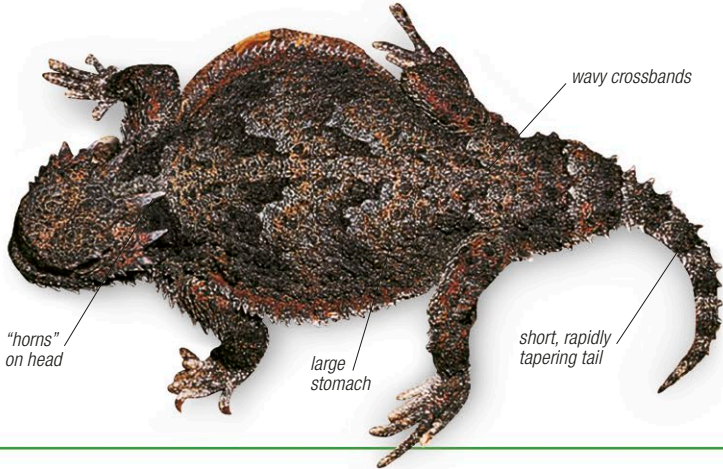
Length 3–5¼ in (7.5–13.5 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S.W. USA



The desert horned lizard is one of 16 closely related species that are scattered across dry habitats in North and Central America. Often known as horned toads, because of their spiky scales and round, squat shape, these lizards specialize in feeding on ants, and rely primarily on camouflage for protection. The desert horned

lizard is relatively smooth-skinned compared to some of its relatives, but has large “horns” on its head, and smaller spikes on its back and tail. Its coloration—gray, reddish, or tan—helps to conceal it on sandy or gravelly ground, as it moves around slowly searching for food. When it locates a column of ants, it feeds voraciously, picking them up with its extendible tongue. If it is threatened with attack, by birds or carnivorous mammals for example, its first reaction is to “freeze” (it is capable of remaining motionless for long periods). If picked up, it inflates its body with air. Females nest in burrows in sand or loose earth, laying 2 clutches of up to 16 eggs each breeding season. Because these lizards have a round, flat shape, they warm up quickly in the morning sunshine. They hibernate during the winter.



Sceloporus occidentalis

Western fence lizard



Length 6–9 in (15–23 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S.W. USA, N.W. Mexico



The main distinguishing feature of this common lizard is the blue patches on its underside and throat. In the western fence lizard, the blue color is most pronounced in the males, and may be faint or entirely absent in females and juveniles. Western fence lizards typically sit on rocks, fences, and other prominent places, bobbing up and down to display their markings to rivals or to potential mates. Highly active, they forage for insects, and in between feeding bouts they bask in the sun. Females usually lay a single clutch of 3–14 eggs.



Oplurus cuvieri

Madagascan collared iguana



Length 12–14½ in (30–37 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Least concern

Location Madagascar, Grand Comoro Island



This is a thickset lizard with a chunky head and spiny tail. Its body is grayish brown, with a distinctive black collar, and speckled brown markings. Males are more intensely colored than females. The Madagascan collared iguana remains motionless for much of the time on a tree trunk, waiting for an insect to come into range before darting out to catch it. When threatened by birds of prey or snakes, it retreats into cracks and crevices in the trunk, using its tail to form a barrier between itself and the predator. Females lay 4–6 eggs in a season.



Liolaemus tenuis

Chilean swift



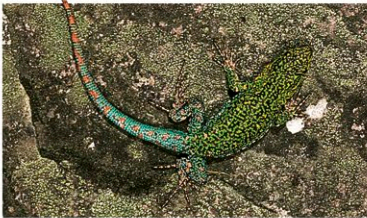
Length 7½–12 in (19–30 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Mostly arboreal
Status Least concern

Location S.W. South America



Also known as the thin lizard, the Chilean swift has a tail that is nearly twice as long as its body. It stalks its insect prey—mainly flies—with the tail

held stiffly over its back. The large, green scales on its body overlap like roof tiles. Chilean swifts live in small groups on trees, with one male and several females occupying a territory. Females lay their eggs in a communal site, often under bark; over 400 eggs have been found in a single site. This lizard hibernates during winter.



Tropidurus hispidus

Guianan lava lizard



Length 5–7 in (13–18 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location N. South America



The Guianan lava lizard is dark brown to black above and white below, with a black collar around the neck. Its flat shape allows it to hide in narrow cracks

and crevices in rocky outcrops, an effective form of protection against predators such as birds, snakes, and larger lizards. The dark color of this lizard probably helps it to warm up quickly as it basks in the sun, usually on vertical surfaces. It forages actively for insects and spiders. Females lay



3 or more clutches of 4–6 eggs in a year.